worked the international situation in their favour through the Americans while holding the line with China, the latter would eventually come around. Once it became evident that the Chinese were ready to re-engage with India, it was only a question of modalities, and here the Indian leadership was willing to offer the fig leaf for China to change tack. John Garver, in his essay in the *China Quarterly 2001*, has claimed that in late January 1999, India's President K.R. Narayanan did a '*mea culpa*' by acknowledging during a meeting with Chinese Ambassador Zhou Gang and former Ambassador Cheng Ruisheng in New Delhi that China did not constitute a threat to India. This was not accurate. In actual fact, the two Chinese diplomats had been invited to tea at Rashtrapati Bhavan (Presidential House) because the Chinese Embassy was offering to assist the President's spouse in publishing the Chinese edition of her book of short stories titled *Sweet and Sour* (this was later published and released during the President's visit to China in May–June 2000). However, in typical fashion, the Chinese used this meeting for their own purposes, and the Indian side did not make an issue of it, if it was going to serve to thaw the relationship.

Once the ice was broken, contact took place between the two foreign ministries. All previous attempts by the Indian Embassy in Beijing to propose various bilateral talks with the Chinese had been met with studied silence. One of the difficulties in dealing with the Chinese, even up to the present day, is the problem of access. Unless they wish to meet you, it is virtually impossible to meet them. In those days, mobile phones were rare and even the internet was uncommon, and even today despite the advantages of modern communications technology in the twenty-first century, the problem remains. In early 1999, the Government of India decided to probe the possibility of a dialogue with the Chinese side, under the rubric